The Lost Land Beneath the Sea

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Imagine a land nearly the size of North America, hidden under the sea. **Geographer** Jerome E. Dobson calls it **Aquaterra**, a name he first proposed in 1999. In a 2014 paper called **Aquaterra** Incognita, he argued that this 22.5-million-square-kilometer **landmass** once hosted some of the earliest human communities and that much of our history may lie beneath the waves.

During ice ages, huge amounts of water froze into glaciers and ice sheets, so sea levels dropped and exposed lowlands that are now underwater. Those lowlands were full of life: grasslands, wetlands, forests, and **estuaries** that drew wildlife and people. Much human progress happened while seacoasts were low, Dobson notes. Early humans lived on such land for the better part of 120,000 years, he argues.

When the glaciers melted, the seas rose again and swallowed those settlements. That does not mean the story ends there. Dobson notes that Jericho is known to have existed when sea levels were about 50 meters lower than today, so finding cities at that depth would not change the timeline of human progress. What could change it, he says, is the possibility that earlier versions of major inventions he mentions pottery as one example lie at even lower depths.

Recent discoveries support the idea. In 2021, researchers Michael K. Faught and Morgan F. Smith described seven projects in North America that found traces of life before European contact, now beneath the shelf. One project in the Gulf of Mexico's paleo-Sabine River turned up charred wood, seeds, fish scales, and bones, some dating back 9,000 years. In Belize, researchers found the outlines of **pole-and-thatch** buildings that had been Maya salt works. Other finds included stone tools and a stone **artifact** more than 12,000 years old.

Word Treasure

Aquaterra -- The name Dobson gave to the huge lost land now hidden under the sea.

Geographer -- A person who studies Earth's lands, seas, and peoples.

landmass -- A very large area of land.

estuaries -- Places where rivers meet the sea and fresh water mixes with salt water.

pole-and-thatch -- Buildings made from wooden poles covered with dried plant material.

artifact -- An old object made by people long ago.

Background you need

Aquaterra is the name for a huge area of land that is now under the sea, once dry land where early people may have lived.

During ice ages, so much water was frozen into glaciers that sea levels fell and low, flat land along the coasts was exposed, full of grasslands, wetlands, and forests where people and animals could live.

When the ice melted, the seas rose again and covered those settlements, so traces of early human life may now lie on the sea floor.

Researchers keep finding signs of that lost world underwater, such as tools, building outlines, and remains of plants and animals, which support the idea that much of our early history is hidden beneath the waves.

Break it down

LEAD: Geographer Jerome E. Dobson calls Aquaterra -- a 22.5-million-square-kilometer landmass now hidden under the sea -- a place that may have hosted some of the earliest human communities.

KEY EVENT: During ice ages, sea levels dropped and exposed lowlands full of grasslands, wetlands, forests, and estuaries; when the glaciers melted, the seas rose again and swallowed those settlements.

+- WHO: Dobson, who first proposed the name in 1999, and researchers Michael K. Faught and Morgan F. Smith, who described seven projects in North America.

+- WHEN: Early humans lived on such land for the better part of 120,000 years; finds date back 9,000 years and more than 12,000 years.

EVIDENCE: Charred wood, seeds, fish scales, and bones from the paleo-Sabine River; pole-and-thatch Maya salt works in Belize; stone tools and a stone artifact more than 12,000 years old.

OPEN QUESTION: Could earlier versions of major inventions, such as pottery, lie at even lower depths and change the timeline of human progress?

Why it matters

If traces of the earliest human communities lie beneath the sea, the story of how people lived, invented, and spread may be far older and wider than the history found on dry land -- and exploring Aquaterra could rewrite what we know about our own past.

Test what you remember

1. What name did geographer Jerome E. Dobson give to the lost land beneath the sea?

(A) Jericho
(B) North America
(C) Aquaterra Incognita
(D) Aquaterra

2. How large is Aquaterra, according to Dobson?

(A) 120,000 square kilometers
(B) 9,000 square kilometers
(C) 22.5 million square kilometers
(D) 50 million square kilometers

3. Why were the lowlands that are now underwater exposed during ice ages?

(A) Huge amounts of water froze into glaciers and ice sheets, so sea levels dropped
(B) Rivers carved new channels to the sea
(C) Earthquakes lifted the seabed
(D) The glaciers melted and raised the land

4. For how long does Dobson argue that early humans lived on such low-lying land?

(A) The better part of 120,000 years
(B) 50 years
(C) 9,000 years
(D) 12,000 years

5. Why would finding cities about 50 meters underwater not change the timeline of human progress?

(A) Because pottery was invented at that depth
(B) Because no cities have ever been found underwater
(C) Because Jericho is known to have existed when sea levels were about 50 meters lower than today
(D) Because the glaciers had already melted by then

6. What did a project in the Gulf of Mexico's paleo-Sabine River turn up?

(A) Pole-and-thatch Maya salt works
(B) A stone artifact more than 12,000 years old
(C) Charred wood, seeds, fish scales, and bones, some dating back 9,000 years
(D) The first pottery ever made

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Jerome E. Dobson: Argues that Aquaterra hosted some of the earliest human communities, that much human progress happened while seacoasts were low, and that earlier versions of major inventions at even lower depths could change the timeline of human progress.

2. Michael K. Faught and Morgan F. Smith: Described seven projects in North America that found traces of life before European contact, now beneath the shelf, supporting the idea that people lived on land that is now underwater.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):